over it, but it wasn't an issue when Udhayanidhi was inducted in 2019, nor when three-time AIADMK chief minister O. Panneerselvam brought his two sons into politics. Among potential challenges, what looms bigger for Udhayanidhi is actor Vijay, who launched his party Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam in February. There are clear overlaps in how the two can attract voters. "Vijay can pose a threat to the DMK and others as well. But the fact that he has no seasoned political mind to guide him can be his undoing, unless something goes terribly wrong with the status quo and people decide en masse to go for a sweeping change," says Moorthy.

NEW CHARGE

- **Udhayanidhi's elevation as Tamil Nadu deputy CM is seen as a fast-track promotion, preparation for 2026 assembly polls**
- **He is expected to form a coterie of loyalists and lead a generational transition in the DMK**
- **Affable and informal, he has formed an instant connect with young voters**

Either way, the DMK cannot afford to sit back and meet the challenge with a greying, geriatric posse. For that, and to minimise anti-incumbency, it might opt for at least a gradual phase-out of veterans closer to the assembly polls. Meanwhile, Udhayanidhi is free to induct and groom his band of loyalists. "Though a confident DMK appears to be well-prepared for 2026, it must have the ability to strike realistic bargains with its allies," says Manivannan.

For now, as deputy CM, Udhayanidhi will have to prove his mettle as the 'rising son' worthy of a prominent place under the DMK's symbol of the rising sun. ■

RAJASTHAN

DOUBLE TROUBLE FOR GEHLOT

By Rohit Parihar



ROHIT JAIN PARAS

It was not an uneven match, but the odds were heavily stacked against Gajendra Singh Shekhawat. For, the personage that the Union minister and Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader from Jodhpur had been embroiled in a political-turned-legal feud with was none other than his hometown rival Ashok Gehlot, the canny Congress veteran who until last December held the reins as chief minister of Rajasthan. "I am the only one of Gehlot's political rivals who could survive his fatal attacks on [their] careers," Shekhawat declared last week, his words hinting at a turning of the tide, as two unrelated developments on September 25 gave him an edge while putting Gehlot in a precarious position.

The roots of this feud can be traced back to 2020 when Gehlot, armed with leaked phone recordings, accused both Shekhawat and his own party colleague, Sachin Pilot, of attempting to topple his government. While Pilot was stripped of his positions as deputy chief minister and state Congress chief, the leaked recordings became the subject of intense scrutiny. Handled by the Special Operations Group (SOG) of Rajasthan Police and later

RARE BONHOMIE Ashok Gehlot (left) with Gajendra Shekhawat, Dec. 2023